Nothing but solid matter, and that of an organic nature, is acted upon by the gastric fluid. Liquids are at once got rid of, and when introduced into the stomach in large quantities, materially interfere with the process of digestion. Solid tissues, such as cooked meat, fish, and bread, are most readily dissolved by the gastric juices. Saccharine and starchy matters are ejected in an unchanged state into the small intestines. Gastric fluid, though poured in large quantities into the stomach during the process of digestion, does not remain there, nor is it all absorbed by the food; some portions of it are reabsorbed into the capillaries which surround and overlay the glands, and thus pass into the general circulation, and perform the function of nourishing or vitiating the tissues of the body; but the greater portion of the solids, when they are susceptible of being dissolved by the gastric juices, are carried off through the pyloric orifice into the duodenum, or first part of the alimentary canal.

The usual length of the small intestine in man is about twenty-five feet. The opening then widens into a much larger passage, called the colon, or great intestine, the length of which, for about five feet, is traversed by the waste matter, which is finally ejected from the system. The intestines, like the stomach, have three coats or membranes, consisting of the peritoneal or serous, the muscular, and the mucous.

The surface of the mucous lining of the small intestine is even more numerously studded with small glands, called villi, than the stomach. Through these